ritual. The appending of the honorific 'ji', connoting respect, is a nod to this stream of veneration.

In 2010, Nitish had quietly held out against even BJP titan L.K. Advani's passionate call for a restoration of Patna's ancient name, Pataliputra. After Gaya, that idea is in circulation again. What the currency of renaming politics in Bihar shows is Nitish's new vulnerability within the NDA. His once-junior coalition partner, the BJP, has clearly taken over the control room: it's scripting the narrative. BJP stalwarts, who had long lobbied for Gaya's renaming, made no secret of their jubilation. Even members of Nitish's JD(U) voiced public approval, nodding to tradition.

This is not the only sign of Nitish's recent deference to his ally. In a February cabinet expansion, he took in seven new ministers—all from the BJP, swelling the saffron contingent to 21, overshadowing the JD(U)'s 13 within the 36-strong ministry. That was both proof of a new ascendancy, and an accelerator of altered dynamics.

SHUTTER STOCK



Takeaways

- **Nitish cabinet clears the renaming of Gaya as Gayaji, as long demanded by BJP**
- **The first renaming in his reign, it shows his diminished clout as NDA readies for polls**

THE BJP'S NEW DOMINANCE

What remains to be seen is the comparative tally after ticket distribution later this year. In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, Nitish had wangled 16 seats and won 12—the same as the BJP's haul from its 17. Yet, in the assembly, 80 chairs are marked saffron (from 37 in 2005). The JD(U) has only 45. The BJP extracts valuable resources from Brand Nitish: his welfarist image, his loyal blocs of women and EBC voters. But it has left in pointed ambiguity the question of remuneration. Nitish still doesn't have the nod as a clear chief ministerial face. For now, he's a useful frontispiece. That the edifice behind him is Hindutva was only reconfirmed at Gaya. ■



COURTING A SENTENCE? MP minister Kunwar Vijay Shah during the speech that brought an FIR on him

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

PATRON OF ABUSE

Why does BJP put up with the verbal iniquities of Vijay Shah, the minister who insulted Col. Sofiya? It's his cachet among MP's tribals

By **Rahul Noronha**

DEFENCE AND GEOPOLITICAL debates may saturate the space presently, but socially no one was in doubt that the post-Pahalgam landscape witnessed a rare degree of Hindu-Muslim solidarity. Of the organic, human sort. The April 22 massacre drew equal, unequivocal condemnation across communities. The Centre even parlayed it off into a wise piece of high-visibility symbolism: choosing